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Shabnam Rakhiba's Guide to Love and Care: Standing by Someone with Chronic Pain

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In the Depths of Pain, Presence is the Greatest Comfort

Personal Journey with Pain

Living with chronic pain has a way of changing everything, including how we understand care and support. When someone is in the midst of a pain flare, words can feel completely inadequate, and finding the right thing to say can seem impossible.

I know this all too well. I've lived with chronic pain for 14 years, starting in my early twenties, though my experience with pain goes back even further. For over two decades, I've dealt with severe menstrual pain and tension headaches lasting months. My diagnosis — endometriosis and fibromyalgia — have made pain a constant in my life.

I've been through flares where hope feels distant, and fear takes over, struggling to maintain any sense of normalcy while pain ravages my body.

The Struggle of Supporting Loved Ones in Pain

In moments where I'm confronted with someone else's pain, my mind sometimes goes blank. Despite my training as a life coach, my Master's in Psychology, and my studies in Acceptance and Commitment Therapy, there are times when I find myself

at a complete loss, unsure of what to say to someone who's in a pain flare because I know there's nothing I can say to take the physical pain away in that moment.

It's ironic, isn't it? With all the knowledge, training & lived experience I have, I still find myself worried at times, not wanting to say the wrong thing.

This reminds me of those who aren't living with chronic illness/pain but who love someone who is chronically ill. I can empathize with how they may feel lost or unsure of how to help. They don't know what to say, and maybe that's why some choose to distance themselves. The discomfort and helplessness are overwhelming, and for some, it feels easier to say nothing or to avoid the situation entirely. For a fleeting moment, I can see why, in their discomfort, people offer well-meaning but sometimes frustrating words, like 'Have you tried X Y Z? Take some meds.'

The Power of Presence from Loved Ones

When I think about my own experience with pain, I often remember my mother. She didn't always know what to say, but she never resorted to empty or hurtful words.

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The sense of helplessness, powerlessness and fear were often vivid in her eyes. She didn't have any magic solutions, though she wished for them. What she gave me was her presence. She stayed with me through the worst of it; sitting by my side, bringing me salty biscuits, the only thing I could eat without vomiting. She offered me cinnamon and thyme tea, hoping each time that it will ease the pain, though it never did. Frequently rearranging his work day, my dad would collect me early from school, drive me to the hospital for a long wait in the emergency room and hunt for various medications that helped very little.

What truly made a difference was that they were there, through every flare, every moment of difficulty. They showed me that sometimes, the most powerful support is simply being present.

We often believe that when someone is suffering, we need to offer grand gestures or words to make a difference. However, in my experience, what people in pain need most isn't advice or comforting phrases. It's the reassurance that someone is there with them, that they aren't facing it alone, and that someone cares enough to stay by their side.

Community Support for Those in Pain

Over the past few years, I've built a community of more than 600 women living with chronic illness and pain in my free Facebook support group. Time and again, I'm asked the same question: "What do I say to someone experiencing a severe flare?" My words may vary, but the message remains constant: "I'm here with you, and I care."

During a recent chronic illness self-care workshop, one participant shared her feelings of overwhelm and grief, only to immediately apologise for 'bringing the group down.' Her apology was a glimpse into the negativity that people living with chronic pain & illness often face when expressing their struggles and challenges. I reassured her that this space isn't for toxic positivity or empty reassurances. It's a space where women can speak their truth and share their raw emotions without fear of judgement.

The Power of Simple Presence

Sometimes, all someone in pain needs is the reassurance that they're not alone and the freedom to express themselves without judgment. Letting them know you're there for the long haul, that you're not going anywhere, creates a safe space for them to open up. This is what helped me navigate the emotional storm that chronic pain brought into my life.

When words feel inadequate, focus on simple acts of care and love. Often, it's the smallest gestures that offer the most comfort — a text saying, "I'm thinking of you," or simply sitting with them in silence, letting

them know you're there if they want to talk. These seemingly small moments carry great power. They remind the person that, even when illness and pain feel overwhelming, they're not facing it alone.

This kind of presence can provide more comfort than any advice or attempt to 'fix' their pain, speaking louder than words ever could.



Shabnam Rakhiba is the founder of Chronic Wellness Lounge and Thorns and Roses Coaching, dedicated to helping women navigate life with chronic illness and pain. With a Master's in Psychology and training in trauma-informed life coaching and Acceptance and Commitment Therapy (ACT), she offers compassionate support through one-on-one coaching, group workshops, and a free Facebook community.

Having lived with chronic pain for over 14 years, Shabnam understands the emotional and physical challenges her clients face. Her approach combines professional expertise with personal empathy, focusing on sustainable wellness and emotional resilience.

As a Muslim, South Asian immigrant who has lived in Mauritius, Bermuda, and the UK, she is committed to addressing health, cultural diversity, and systemic bias in healthcare. Shabnam empowers women to reclaim their lives and advocate for themselves, fostering a safe, inclusive space for sharing stories and seeking support.

Her advocacy also extends to businesses, helping create supportive environments for employees with chronic conditions.

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Constantly being in acute pain can be daunting and often a lonely journey. It is a space to rise and fall in stories of pain, healing, and co-existence.

